

The Cursed Dancers of Colbeck

Carols, wrestling, or summer games: whoever engages in such pastimes in church, or in the churchyard, should be wary of committing sacrilege. And as for comic plays, or singing, or drumming, or playing the pipes, these should all be avoided whilst the priest is celebrating Mass.

All such things are loathsome to every good priest, and nothing, *nothing*, is more likely to anger him than a fool, or anyone who doesn't give the Holy Scripture due respect.

This is particularly true for high days and holidays, when singing songs or reciting rhymes around those holy places might disturb the priest's reverences, for when he is praying, or engaged in any other devotion, then it is *sacrilege*, *wherever* it occurs.

Speaking of such dancing around the churchyard: do I have a tale to tell you! A tale of events that really happened, as true as the Gospel itself.

It happened, as I understand it, in the time of King Edward: a truly terrible tale.

The Tale of the Sacrilegious carolers, and how they danced together for twelve Months without stopping, and then went hopping about singly ever afterwards.

It was **Christmas Eve**, and **twelve revellers** (as the chronicler describes them) arranged "a carol", which is to say, a bit of a party, just for a bit of fun.

They decided to take a trip to the town of **Colbek**. The Church there was dedicated to St Magne, who suffered martyrdom, and also St Bukcestre, St Magne's sister.

I'll mention the revellers' names as I was told them, and as I pronounce them, so that you shall know them to. The leader of the revellers, or so it was written, was a man named **Gerle**. There were also **two young women** in the group, **Mersynde** and **Wybessyne**.

And the **reason** they came to Colbek, and to that Church in particular? That would be the **priest's daughter**. The priest was named Robert, if I remember it correctly, his son was named Azone, and his daughter — the one whom the party-goers had come to meet — she was called **Ave**.

Between them, they agreed who should try to entice Ave out: it would be Wybessyne and Mersynde. The young women approached Ave, and persuaded her to join their party.

Bevune led the dance, and Gerlew suggested what they should sing.

In the original Latin, it was this:

*"Equitabat Beuo per siluam frondosam,
Ducebat secum Merswyndam formosam.
Quid stamus? Cur non imus?"*

which translates as:

*“By the leafy wood rode Bevolyne
And with him the fair Merswyne.
Why should we stay? Why shouldn’t we go?”*

or something like that, and that was the song that Grysly had composed.

They sang it in the **graveyard**, **without caring** for anyone else, even as the prayers were about to said, even as the Mass was about to begin. The priest may well have started to put on his vestments, ready to start the Mass, but that didn’t stop them, and they continued their dancing and frolicking, just as they’d started.

The priest, who was trying to lead the Mass, couldn’t help but hear their **commotion**, so he came down from the altar and went to the Church porch, and said to them: “For God’s sake, will you please just **stop that**? You’re most welcome to come in, and join us. But at the very, please show some respect, and just stop your dancing for now, as we worship the birth of Christ, our Lord, who was born of the Holy Virgin Mary on this sacred night.”

But for all at, they didn’t stop, they just carried on with their singing and dancing.

And quite understandably, the priest wasn’t too happy at this, so he **prayed to God**, believing in his help when it was truly needed, and to Saint Magne, the patron saint of that very Church, that God should act, and **wreak vengeance** on the dancers before they left, by forcing them to **keep on dancing** for a whole year. (*Actually, in the original Latin text, it says “for evermore”.*) Anyway, he cursed them all, or something like that, as they all danced around him, and as soon as he’d finished speaking, the dancers found they **couldn’t let go** of each others’ hands.

“What did he say?” they asked each other, “what was that curse he made?”

and the priest went back inside, telling his **son Azone** to go and **bring Ave back** by whatever means was necessary.

But it was **too late**, because *all* the dancers had been cursed.

Azone quickly set off, to try and bring his sister back, but when he **grabbed her by the arm**, it **came off** in his hands. Quite literally. He ripped it off.

Everyone stared, and gasped, in shock. Because even though Azone had his sister’s arm in his hand, she just **continued dancing**. There was **no blood** anywhere, not from her shoulder, or from the arm. It was a clean break, like a branch snapped off a tree.

Azone **rushed back** to his father with his sister’s arm still in his hand.

“Father... I... This arm... It’s Ave’s... I didn’t mean to, I was just trying to get her to come back...But you cursed her with the rest of them... You asked for vengeance, and

now you've got it."

You might well ask how the priest responded, or how his congregation felt about their priest, who'd called for the dancing to continue, seeing his own daughter cursed along with the rest of them.

Deeply saddened, he took his daughter's arm and **buried it**. But the next day, he found it lying **on the ground**, on top of the grave. So he buried it again. But there it was, once **again**, the very next day, on top of the grave. And the **third time** he buried it, the same thing happened again. There was obviously no reason to believe that he'd have any more success if he tried again, and fearful of what might happen if he left it outside, along with severe regret about the curse he'd made, he carried the arm **inside** the Church and placed it where everyone could see it with their own eyes. As a lesson.

As to the rest of the carollers — the dancers — they carried on dancing for the whole of the year, hand in hand. They **couldn't escape** the place, no matter how hard they tried. The curse that had been made there, would be spent there.

And despite their continuous dancing, it was as if they **never got tired**. They **never ate**, they **never drank**, they **didn't even sleep**, not a single wink.

Whether it was day or night, **whatever the weather**, frost or snow, hail or rain, warm or cold, they seemed **oblivious** to it.

Their **hair never grew** either, nor their **nails**. *Their clothes* never seemed to change, never seemed to need washing, didn't fade in the sunlight. And when the storm clouds thundered, and the lightning struck around them, it never harmed them, as if God's mercy was somehow *protecting* them.

And so they sang:

"Why are we stuck here? Why can't we let go?"

And who in their right mind wouldn't want to go and see such a **spectacle**? The Emperor himself came from Rome to see them, and when he saw them, he cried in sympathy at their misfortune. So he summoned some **carpenters** to make a **shelter** to protect them from the rain. But it was a **pointless** task, because whatever they managed to build during one day had been razed to the ground by the next. Once, twice, three times they tried, but all their efforts came to nothing. It seemed like no covering could protect the dancers unless Christ himself, in his might, would grant them mercy.

At the end of the year, on the next Christmas night, at the **exact same time** that the priest had proclaimed against them the year before, at the **exact same hour** a year later from when he'd first cursed them, the dancers managed to **let go** of each others' hands. Immediately, in the twinkling of an eye, they ran **into the Church** and fell to the floor as if they'd **fainted**. For **three days** they lay there, each of them, not moving a muscle. But then, after three days, it was as if God **raised them up** again, and they

sat up, and each of them spoke to the parish priest, to Sir Robert:

“You were the one who caused the affliction we suffered over the past year. You caused our troubles that everyone came to gawp at. But your own earthly troubles will soon come to an end, because **you’ll return to your eternal home** soon enough.”

At this point, they all **stood up, except for Ave**, the priest’s daughter, who still lay dead. And her Father, and her brother, grieved sorely for her.

I don’t necessarily believe the **priest**’s soul was damned, but I do think that the physical suffering that caused his death was caused by his grief at the loss of his daughter, because he **died** the very next day.

And what of Ave’s arm, the **arm** that couldn’t be buried? Well, the emperor had a **casket** made, and the arm was placed in it, and it was hung up so that all could see it, and reflect on what lesson it might teach them.

And what of the **revellers** who had been locked hand in hand throughout the previous year? Even though they’d now been **separated**, everyone still gawped at them, because that **same hopping dance** that they’d first done, hadn’t stopped: they carried on dancing still. But whereas they hadn’t been able to separate themselves from each other before, now they couldn’t stand (in many senses of the word) to remain in the same place, at the same time, together.

Four of them made their **separate ways** to the court of Rome, dancing all of the way there, though they never crossed each others’ paths again. Their clothes never faded, never even needed washing; their hair and their nails never grew, and they never found a cure to stop the dancing, not at any any shrine, except for one: to St Edith, where Saint Theodoric was given a cure on Our Lady’s Day, in Lenten time, as he slept beside her tomb.

It was Brunnyng, the Bishop of Saint Toulous, who wrote this marvellous tale. He was even more revered, later, under the name they knew him by in Rome, and in the chronicles, and in many places beyond the sea: as Pope Leon.

As the old saying goes, “**The nearer to the church, the further from God.**” So pay due regard to the lesson of this tale. Some say, it is but an **idle story** while others believe it to be the truth, wondering at it, as a marvel, a **clear example and a dreadful warning, against cursing**. But **also** as a warning **against dancing** in church, or in the churchyard, especially when the priest tells you not to: just leave quietly if he asks you to settle down and you don’t believe you can.